

Hey, everybody. Welcome to your Chapter 2 review. In this episode, we're covering the personal training profession. We're going to pull back the curtain a little and give you some insight into what a career as a CPT really looks like. And we'll also cover the key learning points in this chapter. It's going to leave you with a lot to think about.

Let's start with this. What inspired you to become a CPT? I mean, really stop and think about it. The vast variety of opportunities in the fitness industry can be both a blessing and a curse. It can be hard to hone in on what you really want to do. So take the time now to think about what environment you want to work in and what types of clientele you want to work with. This might even change over the course of your career, but everybody needs a good starting point.

And let's be realistic. It's not all going to be just working out, blasting fun music, and chatting with your new gym friends and clients while chugging down a delicious protein shake. I mean, hopefully that, too. But there's an entrepreneurial business side of things that is actually the make or break for fitness pros.

Just like anyone working to build their own business, you'll need a marketing strategy with competitive branding and promotions. You'll have recordkeeping responsibilities and forecasting. You'll need to sharpen your sales skills and prospect for qualified leads. In essence, you're going to have to get ready for the facts and figures side of things, as well as the science of training the body and customer service components.

Oh, and of course, before you even get started, you'll have to put together a great resume and develop your interviewing and client-building skills. If you're feeling overwhelmed, don't worry. NASM, as usual, has covered with all you need to know about career development to set yourself up for success.

OK, here's your list of learning points. Once you get through this chapter, you'll have a better grasp on how to discover employment opportunities as an entry level fitness professional; craft a professional resume and hone interview skills; describe the most common daily job tasks for fitness professionals; develop sales and marketing strategies to drive clientele growth; and identify requirements and opportunities for continuing education in the fitness industry. That's your high-level overview. Like I said, don't be overwhelmed. It all makes sense when you break it down, which we're going to do right now.

History is important. Seeing the progression of where we've come from gives us context for what we do and insight about where we might be going. It also teaches us about the stigmas associated with fitness trainers that may still need to be overcome. The profession of personal training can trace its origins to the 1970s, when bodybuilders and athletes were hired to help clients develop their muscular appearance. It was kind of that simple. Commercial health club growth was also on the rise, with owners quickly realizing they could create another revenue stream by offering personal training services to members.

But fast forward past the Spandex and Jazzercise. As the personal training profession grew, credibility and certification became more and more important. Attaining certification through an accredited program gives potential employers and clients the confidence you've put in the work, and can back up your words with the commitment you've put into your education.

Current ACPTs are responsible for designing exercise programs that integrate all systems of the body, and use a variety of exercises to improve balance and coordination, core strength, and overall movement quality and health. The function of a CPT has evolved from a focus on just aesthetic appearance to a deeper involvement in helping clients improve their overall wellness and quality of life.

With programs designed specifically for weight loss, injury prevention, athletic performance, and improving daily function, from working in a large health club to training clients in their own homes, there are many, many options to establish a thriving personal training practice. You could start a fitness business that runs outdoor group workout programs, or you could open a studio. As technology advances and safety around gathering in groups can sometimes be an issue, there are even options for offering training services online.

Additionally, you have choices about working for yourself or someone else. As an independent contractor, you can establish your own pay rates. Just keep in mind that operational expenses, insurance costs, and taxes are line items you'll be responsible for. If you choose to start your career working for a health club, this can offer stability and help establish some great foundational skills necessary for long-term success, and maybe even starting your own business further down the road. All of these pathways are viable career options if you have a plan in place.

So let's say you've earned your NASM CPT credential, which of course, you will. Now you'll need a well-crafted resume to attract those interviews. Keep it short and sweet. And don't be worried that you may not immediately have specific experience working in the fitness industry. Focus on your strengths, and highlight other skills and job experiences that can easily transfer, especially those in customer service and sales-oriented roles.

Once you get a gym shoe-clad foot in the door, make sure you communicate effectively, openly, and honestly in your interviews. You have a lot of unique and awesome qualities to bring to the table. Let them see that.

All right, we also have to tackle the business side of things. A viable and lucrative career in fitness takes an understanding of the human body and principles around exercise, but also requires a certain level of business acumen, too. Whether you're working as a health club employee or doing your own thing, fitness pros are responsible for operating their own business.

The first step to success is offering uncompromising customer service and client management. Client management includes doing all the necessary paperwork, reviewing assessments and intake forms, tracking client progress, and if you're self-employed, preparing invoices and collecting payments. You'll have to set aside some structured time for developing or updating exercise programs. Then there's followup phone calls, emails, and text messages to schedule and confirm appointments.

If you're working for someone else, they might already have systems in place. If you're on your own, there are some great resources and apps for marketing, communications, and bookkeeping. You're going to give a lot of yourself physically, mentally, and emotionally to this career. To avoid burnout and maintain a healthy work-life balance, set regular hours, and keep to your appointment times.

Clients need to understand that they are paying for your time. If they're late, the session should still end when it's scheduled to and not run into the next client session. Your clients will appreciate the ability to establish and maintain a consistent schedule. And trust me, your sanity will appreciate it, too.

And now, time for some sales talk. Some people are natural at sales. And others, well, they might have to approach it from a different angle. While the end goal is asking a client to make a commitment to an exercise program to improve their own health, wellness, and fitness, selling is really just creating a rapport with prospective clients, uncovering their needs, and presenting solutions to fulfill those needs. Look at it as the first step in providing awesome customer service.

If you're properly building rapport, sales will feel natural and automatic. And don't forget to use forecasting techniques so you can determine how many prospective clients you'll need to contact to meet with, and how many clients you'll need to service to support your financial goals. Hand in hand with your sales strategy will be marketing. Marketing is the process of promoting your services by communicating the features, advantages, and benefits to your potential clients to meet their needs.

Identify your unique selling proposition and what makes you stand out from others featuring a similar service. To help simplify the process, make sure your marketing plan includes the four P's of marketing, or product, price, promotion, and place. If you work for a health club, new members are often provided with complimentary training sessions to help CPTs build their clientele. And when you're not working with a client, you have the advantage of being able to work the floor to meet new members and establish rapport.

When you're just starting out, it could take as long as three to six months to develop a full client schedule. That's OK. There's a lot you can do to build your business during that time. You'll be making connections, advertising your services. And don't forget about social media, industry events, and networking, and other digital marketing campaigns. Like I said, lots to do.

Lastly, I can't emphasize this enough. It's of critical importance to continue your education. The best CPTs are lifelong learners. Continuing Education, or Con Ed for short, is not only a requirement to maintain your credentials, it can also help expand your business to new and exciting markets by learning how to work with different specialty populations. To keep up your certification, you'll need to total two Continuing Education Units, or CEUs, which equates to roughly 20 hours worth of Con Ed every two years.

The two most popular methods are attending live events like workshops or conferences and completing online education courses. There are also opportunities to participate in live stream webinars, read fitness articles, and/or pass a quiz or test to demonstrate your knowledge. Eventually, you may be able to create content for fitness education programs, speak at conferences, or present a webinar yourself.

Now, there could be a temptation to overlook or dismiss the CEUs. But honestly, there are few things more unprofessional than not maintaining your certification. It comes off as a lack of commitment, unwillingness to grow, or even just laziness, without the desire to stay current and relevant with the latest evidence-based methods. The truth is that continuing education can be fun, engaging, and a way to keep things fresh for you.

Over the past 50 years or so, the personal training field has evolved a lot. What began as a fairly limited niche has become an entire industry, focused on using exercise and physical activity to improve a wide range of fitness goals and promote overall health and wellness. There are tremendous opportunities to build a viable and lucrative career in fitness while making a difference in people's lives.

To do that, it's not only going to take an understanding of the human body and principles around exercise, but also a fair amount of business savvy, particularly around sales, marketing and best-in-class customer service. Bottom line, it requires a lot of work, but it's so worth it. Happy studying.